

PART I

In the beginning I knew nothing. Because other than myself there existed nothing for me to know about. After spending countless millennia wondering around aimlessly in a mindless state, the first time in my existence, I saw another living creature. It was not a friendly one. It's monstrous size and strength horrified me as it gnawed at my flesh tearing my body apart, eating away my limbs one by one. I screamed in pain until my lungs gave out. It was clear I was being consumed as sustenance, and yet, no matter how much it mutilated me, I did not die. And so I learned the first thing about myself, a thing which terrified me beyond measure, I was immortal. Well, that is as long as I'm stuck here, I would not taste the sweet release of death. Nothing could ever defeat me. But as my severed head lay on the hard concrete floor, I could do nothing but watch, as the only other living being I knew of, devoured whatever remained of my body. I was immortal, yes, but not invincible. The creature, heaven knows why, settled on leaving behind my head untouched. And as it walked away, I did nothing, simply watched as the only organism other than me which I knew to be sentient, slowly walked away. I watched as it eventually disappeared on the borderless white horizon. Then for once more, I was alone. It must have been centuries that I just laid there. Only me, alone with my thoughts, stuck inside this flesh prison that couldn't so much as breathe. But, it gradually grew outwards. I lost count how long it took for my body to grow back to its former self, but it did. Laying there, in intolerably excruciating pain, I fantasized endlessly and dreamt about the day when I'll get up again, when I'll move again, when I'll breathe again. I dreamed of being happy, content, relieved; feeling like I was going to explode with joy. But when the long awaited time finally arrived, I felt nothing. Absolutely nothing. Neither anything good, nor anything foul, just an empty void. So, I got up and began walking. Again. I walked and wandered the white featureless concrete plains, blinding whiteness for as far as I could see, stretching out in all possible directions. On that issue, the plains reflected the state of my mind; unfathomable blankness. For as long as I was here, I never again came across anything else which had a beating heart; not even the pleasant fellow that had previously feasted upon me had crossed paths with me. But what I did come across was knowledge. You see, millennia of complete isolation had initially destroyed my mind from the inside. Deteriorated it to nothing but a husk of what it used to be. That is to say, I had gone insane and I remained that way for god knows how long. But eventually, as time passed, I began to regain my senses. Perhaps the incident with that rabid creature had somehow triggered it. Or Maybe it was something else. Who knows? All I knew was that immediately after that event, and my subsequent recovery thereof, I began to learn. I began to learn all sorts of things; from the composition of the concrete I was standing on, to the abstract concepts of quantum chromodynamics. I don't know how, nor why it happened, but it did. Its just one of those things, I guess, that simply does. Every once in a while, I would find things written on the ground. Equations, concepts, explanations, random bits of knowledge. Funny thing is, I never really got to meet who wrote them. I studied them, and Oh boy did I study them! In the millennia to come, I would accumulate more knowledge than old-me could ever have imagined. And for the first time in eternity, I felt like I finally had a purpose. More importantly, I felt something. And that's what kept me going. Then the day came, I had finally found the piece of knowledge I was looking for. The secret to The pathway. I wanted to forever say farewell to this white infinite plain of nothingness. I did not, for a single second longer, wish stay in this ugly place. And that is what I did. I can not believe it was ever so simple. Just do some random movements, at the right place, at the right time and voilà! You're out. The endless plains around me began to crumble, the white sky collapsing in on itself, the ground split asunder; the end had finally arrived. A tingling sensation started in my feet which gradually made its way up to my noggin. And then I heard another human voice for the first time in

eons, "Professor, did it work?" I was back, my dreaded memory of that accursed void already slipping away from my mind as if it were just a dream. I looked around and found myself in a portal, an opening to an Einstein-Rosen Bridge, surrounded by faces I was slowly beginning to once again recognise. I was truly back.

PART II

My entrance was not something that would fit the definition of a 'soft landing', but regardless, I found myself again on solid ground and that's all that mattered. In front me, I discovered a whole new world never previously seen, heard or felt by anyone other than me. I had pioneered trans-dimensional travel. The intoxicating feeling of accomplishment, along with the intense ringing sound in my ears as I reeled from the crash, managed to momentarily blindside me to the predicament I found myself in. But once I had sufficiently reveled in my own glory, that realization hit me like a tranquillizer dart. My pod had become disconnected, and as such, I had no discernible way to make the journey back home. I was, for all intents and purposes, stuck. So, like any rational man, I panicked. I scoured through the wreckage to find anything to re-establish contact, but to no avail. I, however, was in no mood to accept my position; it was too distressing of a possibility to come to terms with. Instead, I convinced myself that I was overthinking it, jumping to conclusions, and considering only the worst-case scenarios, that it was only an emotional response to an unprecedented crisis, that if I simply kept my head cool, I'd be able to tackle the problem. So, I decided to take a look around the place, see if I could find some water or anything of the sort, test my luck and whatnot... I wish I hadn't. I wish I had stayed. I wish I had remained paralyzed by fear, instead of leaving just to maintain the facade of fearlessness. But as much as I regret it, I didn't stay.

I made my way towards a tree I saw in the distance. It was one of many such plant-like entities in my general vicinity. Yet, on reaching said 'tree', I realized it was nothing of the sort, if anything, it was an outward projection of the ground itself. I checked the other ones, and inferred the same result. And then the great spiral downwards began. I turned around, and behind me I saw nothing. Just the plain savannah stretching to the horizon, with groves of trees scattered here and there along the way. My pod, whatever remained of it, had vanished. I ran to the spot it had previously occupied, but I found nothing. No sign of anything nor of anyone taking off with my pod. And yet, it wasn't there. It had simply dissipated into thin air. At first, I attributed it to my "supposed" crash. A concussion maybe? Perhaps a very lucid hallucination? Maybe the pod wasn't ever there in the first place? I mean, how else is one to explain a spontaneous disappearance? I waited in that place for hours, but the hours soon turned into days, and the days turned into weeks. The indifferent passage of time continued, yet still, neither did anything, nor did anyone, show up. Everything remained in an unaltered state of being. Nothing, and I can't stress this enough, absolutely nothing happened. Soon, I began to notice I no longer felt hunger or thirst, didn't also feel the urge to fall asleep. It seemed as if I had been liberated from any and all physical needs against my will. And in turn, I too had become like the spotless soil, like the tiny blades of grass, like the strange tree-like imitations; simply existing in a grotesquely constant world. But, when the weeks began turning into months, I had had enough. I began to walk.

As I walked under the unmoving sun, the featureless soil grew evermore featureless. Those caricature of autotrophs, evermore scarce. The grass soon faded away, leaving behind only the barren sand. The trees followed suit, stranding me in an endless desert. I didn't pay much heed to that though. I didn't pay much heed to anything. My first few hours here were eventful, or at least, I like to think so. I started

with the sensory overload of landing on an alien planet, followed by indescribable fear, and finally mind-numbing anxiety from the perceived bleakness of my future. But as time progressed, all my senses dulled down, like a blade in dire need of honing. Like an axe too blunt to even cut butter. By the end of my first year, I barely felt anything, if ever. I woke up from my daze, one day, when I looked up at the sky. The stationary sun which was once the only ornament up above, was no longer present, a featureless veil of white placed in lieu of it. I marveled at the sight for a moment prior to returning back to my perpetual state of being. The ground had long ago lost its texture, and now, the sky had too. I continued walking across the desolate landscape. And I still am. Why do I walk? I don't know. How long have I been walking? Not even a clue. Where am I headed? Heaven only knows. Do I even remember who I was, or where I came from? I'm not entirely certain I do. Everything has ceased to matter. But in all that absurdity, I believe I have found some wisdom; Meaning is a myth, concocted by those too afraid to admit, that the default state of existence is meaninglessness. There is only one point to my existence now, and that point is, that everything is pointless; however self-contradictory that may sound.

PART III

Have you ever seen a man dissolve? Because I would not recommend it.

"Long time no see," I heard Ali say. He had somehow crept up on me while I was mindlessly roaming about. He didn't appear to be in good shape, kind of mirrored my position in more ways than one. I was, understandably, ecstatic to see him. The rush of dopamine in seeing another human face made me feel like I was on the verge of passing out. We embraced each other and broke down crying. The tormenting emptiness of this purgatory had really taken its toll on us. But now, we had each other. And even though we were both irreversibly traumatised, at least we were no longer alone.

Ali gave me a much needed break, and I'm sure he'd say the same. Speaking was difficult at first because we had forgotten how to, but eventually, we got back our rhythm. It was liberating beyond words to finally communicate with someone again, to know that we were not alone. We talked for days on end, discussing trifles about our former lives, about how we found ourselves trapped here, about the things we experienced upon landing here, and so on and so forth. But once we reached that point, we found we had nothing more to say, because once our pods had dissipated, nothing more followed except the brain rotting absence of any events.

In a surprising twist however, Ali and I soon began noticing those tree-like projections we had left behind eons ago. And so, we began to sprint. Something was finally happening. Whatever it was, we had finally reached our long awaited destination. We ran and we ran, for as long as it took. The grass soon began reappearing, and so did other plants. On the horizon, we saw movement, the first we'd ever seen, and we bolted towards it without any hesitation. I was certain it was another pod sent in to rescue us. Even if it was not, we were on to something, something alive. And that was enough for us both.

At the end of the clearing, we stopped. There stood a solitary pod. Ali rushed to examine it, but I didn't. Something else had caught my eyes, a person, a person I knew very well. To the left of the craft, I saw my wife, just standing there. Emotions overcame me as tears welled in my eyes. I didn't know how she had gotten there, and I couldn't have cared less. All I could think about at that moment was to hold her

in my arms again. And that's what I did. I held her as tight as I could, kissed her, and told her how much I missed her. Her soft hair brushed against my face as I cried my heart out into her shoulders. My wife, also in tears by now, reminded me how much she loved me, and the sound of her voice made me jump instantly from the deepest pit of despair to the highest sit in heaven. The happiness I felt, the reassuring calmness that her words delivered me, was simply beyond words. I felt enraptured, euphoric, elated – and a multitude of other good feelings I can't quite describe. My thoughts raced as fast as my heart. I remembered all the angelic times we had spent together, and felt euphoria at the thought of being given the chance to re-enact them. I unknowingly began going over all our memories; not only the good ones but even the bad ones; because every single second with her was worth more to me than all the time in this foul dimension combined. I remembered our first date, our wedding, all the times we had had an argument, and all the times we didn't have argument. I even remembered her death.

Her death.

She died 2 years before I came here. Sudden onset glioblastoma. There was nothing the doctors could do about it.

And yet, she was here.

I looked at her, but the words wouldn't leave my mouth. She caressed my face longingly, and said as she kissed me, "Oh honey, don't you get it yet? We're all just a dream. Figments of your imagination."

And with that she was gone. I collapsed onto my knees, and through my tear blurred vision, I saw Ali for the last time, as he dissolved into the air. I looked around, and found myself alone, in the all too familiar ever-empty void of nothingness.

And that's when I lost it.

The next thing I remember is being mauled by a monster for food.

So, I ask again; have you ever seen a man dissolve?

Because I would not recommend it.